

8000 ▶ 3000 BCE

Research at the site of Çatalhöyük has revealed 18 layers of buildings.

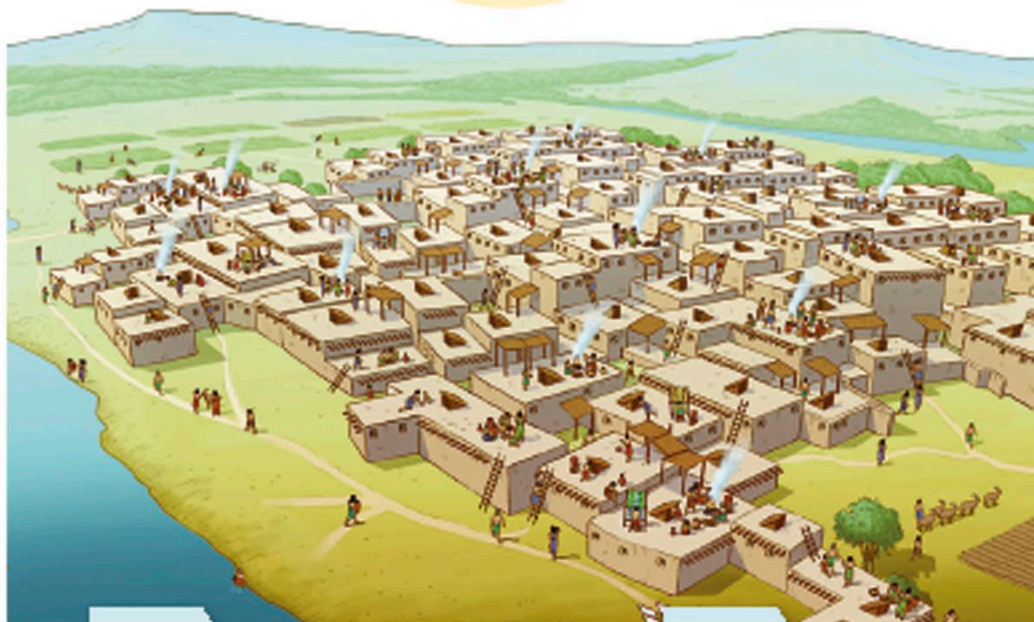
Ancient architecture
See pages 26–27

7400 BCE

Earliest town

Built on a mound in what is now southern Turkey, Çatalhöyük was the world's earliest town. It was home to between 3,500 and 8,000 inhabitants, who lived in tightly packed mud-brick houses. There were no streets between the houses and people moved around on the rooftops, or by using ladders.

Reconstruction of Çatalhöyük based on excavations



Pottery kiln

The kiln, an oven for firing clay pottery, was invented in Mesopotamia (now Iraq). In a kiln, the clay is placed apart from the heat source. This allows higher temperatures to be kept up for longer, making stronger pots than earlier methods.



8000

7000

6000

6500 BCE

Smelting copper

Copper objects, made by hammering the raw metal into shape, were by this time widely used. People had first begun working copper in 9000 BCE. The earliest evidence of copper smelting—heating rocks containing copper mixed with other substances—was found in Turkey, and dates from about 5500 BCE (see p.18).

6000 BCE

The ard plow

The earliest farmers worked with hand tools, using hoes with blades to make holes in the soil for sowing seed. Later, by attaching the hoe to a long pole with a cross-beam, they created the first type of plow, called the ard. Developed in Mesopotamia, the ard allowed larger areas to be farmed and seed to be sown more efficiently.

Spindle whorl

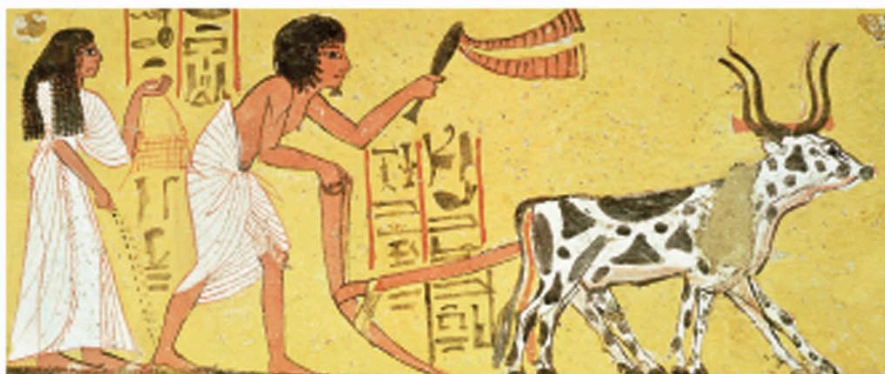
Around 6000 BCE, people in the Middle East learned to make textiles by twisting and pulling raw wool or cotton on a thin rod, or spindle. By fitting a weighted disc called a whorl to the spindle, they could spin faster.



5500 BCE

First irrigation canals

Farmers at Choga Mami in eastern Iraq dug channels to carry water from the Tigris River to their fields. These irrigation canals made it possible to grow crops in areas where there was little rainfall.



Ancient Egyptian tomb painting showing a farmer working with an ox-drawn ard plow